

IELTS READING

PRACTICE TEST

Building the Titanic: Constructing the 'Unsinkable' Ship

Diane Trang reviews maritime historian John Bannister's new book on the infamous ship

Building the Titanic by John Bannister offers readers a captivating history of the RMS Titanic – a ship that symbolises luxury, ambition, and eventual tragedy. The book is painstakingly researched, bringing together financial data, social history, and insights into developments in engineering, to explain why and how the Titanic was built. A major achievement is Bannister's ability to convey the emotions experienced by key participants at each stage of the Titanic's story. Most books written about this ship take the approach of explaining the reasons for the tragic sinking of the Titanic in their accounts of how it was built. Bannister reserves the tragedy for the second half of the book so that during the early chapters, the reader can relive the excitement that surrounded the construction of the ship.

Chapter one sets the stage in the early 20th century with an analysis of the socio-economic factors that led to the Titanic's conception. Bannister's exploration of the intense competition among the shipping companies of the day provides important insight into why the White Star Line, Titanic's owners, were so determined to build the world's largest passenger ship. Later in the book, when trying to make sense of decisions about the ship's construction and sailing that appeared hasty or even foolish, I found it helpful to recall this chapter's explanation of the huge pressure White Star's owners faced.

Chapter two explains the complex financial deals behind the Titanic's construction. Bannister outlines the huge budget required by White Star, calculating it at an astonishing US\$7.5 million, equivalent to approximately \$200 million today. Interestingly, when he investigates the role played by the International Mercantile Marine Company (IMM) in providing the necessary financing, Bannister draws a unique conclusion. He first explains a complicated sequence of share and bond issuing by both IMM and White Star. He then uses this to convincingly reject the widely reported idea that IMM financed the Titanic and argues instead that White Star financed IMM. It is an intriguing idea that warrants further investigation.

Chapter three details the design and engineering marvels that defined the Titanic. Bannister provides a long list of specifics, such as the ship's length (to the centimetre), the number of rivets used and the precise amount of steel in the hull. Not being an engineering enthusiast, I must admit my attention drifted a little here. Luckily, the chapter is saved by a fascinating discussion of how the premium materials used in the construction fostered the infamous belief that the Titanic was 'unsinkable'.

Chapter four paints a vivid picture of what it was like to work on the construction of the Titanic at the Harland and Wolff shipyard in Belfast. A staggering 3,000 workers were involved, and Bannister meticulously describes the diverse range of skilled professionals, including boilermakers, electricians, and plumbers, who contributed their expertise. An especially rewarding aspect of this chapter is the inclusion of first-hand accounts from workers' letters and diary entries. Reading these, it becomes clear that while workers faced long hours, poor safety standards and low wages, they were also swept up in the excitement of constructing the largest ship ever built. Bannister closes the first part of the book with an account of the ship's launch in 1911, watched by 100,000 spectators – a clear example of how Titanic had captured the public imagination.

Questions 27–30

Do the following statements agree with the claims of the writer in the reading passage?

Choose **YES** if the statement agrees with the claims of the writer, choose **NO** if the statement contradicts the claims of the writer, or choose **NOT GIVEN** if it is impossible to say what the writer thinks about this.

- 27 Information in chapter one helps the reader to understand later chapters.
- 28 At the time of construction, the Titanic was the most expensive ship ever built.
- 29 The detailed figures in chapter three lack interest.
- 30 Professional workers who constructed the Titanic were paid well for their skills.

Questions 31–35

Complete the summary using the list of phrases, A–J, below.

Sea trials

At the start of the second part, Bannister describes the Titanic's sea trials, which were delayed due to

31. in the Irish Sea. The trials required the ship to perform 32. that tested its readiness for its first ocean voyage. A key part of the trials was measuring the distance needed to achieve a 33.

Bannister challenges the idea that the sea trials produced 34. He argues that the measurements taken were troubling, and should have led to a reduction in 35. that may have avoided the tragic consequences of the Titanic's collision with the iceberg.

- | | | |
|---------------------------|----------------------|-------------------------|
| A specific movements | B financial setbacks | C catastrophic failures |
| D unpredictable behaviour | E speed limit | F rapid acceleration |
| G impressive results | H poor conditions | I complete stop |
| J full turn | | |

 **IELTS Reading – Section 3 (Text)****Building the Titanic: Constructing the ‘Unsinkable’ Ship**

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Building the Titanic: Constructing the ‘Unsinkable’ Ship (cont.)

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The second part of the book begins by detailing the Titanic’s highly anticipated sea trials. After waiting for bad weather to pass, the Titanic sailed into the Irish Sea to undergo testing. This involved assessing the ship’s forward speed and ability to turn, to ensure that it would be safe to sail. In particular, Bannister describes the important test of the Titanic’s ability to quickly come to a halt, in which the engines were sent into reverse, and the distance travelled while the ship reached a speed of zero was measured. In his discussion of the results of these tests, Bannister opposes the popular opinion that the trials were a great success and further proof of the ship’s ‘unsinkable’ status. In fact, Titanic was slow to stop and required a wide turning circle. Had these worrying deficiencies been recognised, Bannister believes the ship’s permitted maximum speed would have been slower, meaning that on that fateful night, it may not have hit the iceberg and the many deaths would not have occurred.

Chapters six and seven cover the four days of the Titanic’s maiden voyage in April 1912. Bannister joyfully describes the colourful characters both above and below deck, from Isidor and Ida Straus in first class, the wealthy owners of famous American department store Macy’s, to the Sages, a family of 11 travelling in third class. Those who are familiar with the depiction of the difficult conditions in third class in the 1997 film, *Titanic*, will be surprised by Bannister’s description, based on his extensive research. Third-class cabin beds were comfortable, nourishing meals were provided, and White Star appears to have genuinely valued its third-class customers. These and other details expertly paint a picture of what it was like to travel aboard Titanic, so that when tragedy strikes, readers are all the more invested in the fate of the passengers. However, the description of the collision, when it arrives, is something of a disappointment. So much has already been documented about the night Titanic struck the iceberg, and Bannister unfortunately has little new information to add about how or why the ship sank.

Ultimately, *Building the Titanic* is a captivating read, packed with fascinating new information and characterisation that brings the story of the Titanic back to life. However, readers hoping for original insights into the ship’s final hours are unlikely to be completely satisfied.



IELTS Reading – Section 3 (Questions)

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- | | | |
|----------------------------------|-----------------------------|--------------------------------|
| A specific movements | B financial setbacks | C catastrophic failures |
| D unpredictable behaviour | E speed limit | F rapid acceleration |
| G impressive results | H poor conditions | I complete stop |



Questions 36–40

Choose the correct answer.

36 What does Trang say about Bannister's book in the first paragraph?

- A** It takes a similar approach to other books about the Titanic.
- B** It examines a variety of factors that influenced the construction of the Titanic.
- C** It focuses on the roles of key people involved in the Titanic's construction.
- D** It offers an original explanation for why the Titanic sank.

37 How does Trang respond to the information in the book about financing?

- A** She shows how Bannister's theory contradicts that of other writers.
- B** She describes where Bannister did his research.
- C** She signals a problem with Bannister's explanation.
- D** She explains the significance of Bannister's argument.

38 What did Trang enjoy most about the chapter on Titanic's workers?

- A** the information about the working conditions
- B** the way Bannister ends the chapter
- C** the sources Bannister uses to tell the workers' stories
- D** the details on the different jobs needed for construction

39 Trang mentions the film Titanic to

- A** suggest that Bannister's account is wrong.
- B** emphasise the importance of the Sage family.
- C** highlight how fiction differs from reality.
- D** show how badly the Titanic passengers were treated.

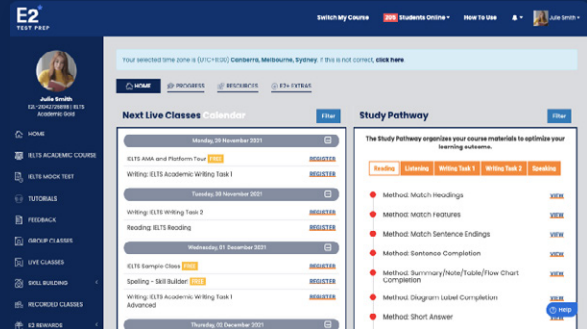
40 What does Trang suggest about the chapters describing the Titanic's maiden voyage?

- A** The explanation that is given for the ship's sinking is unclear.
- B** More details are needed about the passengers' experiences.
- C** The information about third class is confusing.
- D** Some aspects of the chapters are more successful than others.



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34 G
33 I
32 A
31 H

38 C
37 A
36 B
35 E

40 D
39 C

30 NO
29 YES
28 NOT GIVEN
27 YES

ANSWERS